

SEASON 01 EPISODE 09

Forgive Me Father

1 **INT. JUNIPER'S HOME - DAY** 1

An empty desk seats no one. It's Juniper's room.

JUNIPER (V.O.)
In the year and three months after
Bullock was elected, guess what
changed?

2 **INT. LOUIS'S HOME - DAY** 2

LOUIS, grizzly bear, and Juniper- younger- at their desks.

JUNIPER (V.O.)
Nothing.

3 **EXT. DOWNTOWN - DAY** 3

Numbers on a screen.

JUNIPER (V.O.)
Bullock continued to push the budget
further in canids' and bovines'
favor.

Adeline and Gurnick on the podium.

JUNIPER (V.O.)
Adeline and Gurnick announced their
concessions. Though they were more
grievances than concessions.

Eve with Fergie.

JUNIPER (V.O.)
Eve continued her band.

Everyone in class.

JUNIPER (V.O.)
We all continued school.

4 **EXT. TALENS HIGH - DAY** 4

TEACHER A
Avians-

TEACHER B
Reptiles-

TEACHER C
Mammalians-

TEACHER D
5 power e square root 2, derivative-

TEACHER E
Constructing grammar and semantics-

TEACHER F
Supply and demand-

TEACHER G
Mitochondria-

These teachers appear in rappid succssion, until finally-

5 INT. CAFETERIA - DAY

5

Louis and Juniper, sit with EVE, PETUNIA, and ROSALINE-rabbit, beaver, otter- at the table, exhausted.

A fight breaks out behind them. They don't even notice.

No words spoken.

On the halls:

CONGRATS CLASS OF 2022- YOU MADE IT!

6 EXT. DOWNTOWN - DAY

6

Louis and Juniper walk side by side. They don't say a word.

But the signs on the floor say everything.

Behind them, Petunia and Rosaline trail on by.

It's like a ghost town.

They reach the tracks, wave each other off. Juniper joins Louis and Eve.

7 EXT. TRAIN TRACKS - DAY

7

Eve waves, splits off. Louis and Juniper cross.

8 INT. LOUIS'S HOME - DAY

8

It's quiet. The two boys enter.

Juniper brings out his lunchpail.

JUNIPER
Here.

LOUIS
I don't want any food.

JUNIPER
I wanna share it.

Louis leans back in his chair, accepts it.

Louis grabs a piece of paper, begins studying...

His leg rustles.

LOUIS
I have an idea.

Juniper glances up.

9 EXT. OUTSKIRTS - DAY

9

Louis and Juniper wander through the outskirts, gliding their hands through the leaves in grievance.

They sit by the rock, and FJORD- the bustling city- in the distance.

They glance at it. It looms like a monolithic, concrete castle.

They get to work.

Juniper puts his back to Louis. Louis puts his back to Juniper.

LOUIS
Can you help me with this one?

Juniper glances.

JUNIPER
96.

Louis writes 96.

They continue to write. They press up against each other's backs.

Louis sets down his pencil. He moves his hand down to his side-

And his arm touches Juniper's back.

Juniper's breathing grows faster and faster. He turns around-

AND RIGHT THEN AND THERE, BEGINS KISSING LOUIS.

Louis and Juniper kiss, grabbing each others' bodies, pushing against one another-

As their pencils roll down the hill.

10 **INT. CLASSROOM - DAY** 10

HAZEL, Louis's sister, and SIENNA, black bear, sit on opposite sides of the classroom.

They write. Hazel raises her hand.

HAZEL
Can I use the restroom?

11 **EXT. CLASSROOM - DAY** 11

Hazel runs down the hall. She SPRINTS.

She passes by graduation poster after graduation poster.

Footsteps behind her. It's Sienna's.

She sprints, fast-

12 **INT. BATHROOM - DAY** 12

Then LOCKS HERSELF INSIDE.

BANG! BANG! BANG!

Hazel sinks to the floor, sobbing quietly.

HAZEL
Someone... please, I can't do this anymore.

FADE TO BLACK.

A sermon.

FATHER
Our father, who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy name.

JUNIPER (V.O.)
In history, only some things
survive. Prayers, pleas, cries...

FATHER
Thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
as earth as it is in heaven.

JUNIPER (V.O.)
Most cries fade. The ones that stay
are ones like these.

13 **INT. CHAPEL - DAY** 13

Juniper holds hands with:

LAUREL, his oldest sister, and JANE and SEYMOUR, his parents.

FAMILY

Give us this day, our daily bread,
and forgive us our trespasses, as we
forgive those who trespassed against
us-

JUNIPER (V.O.)

The fancy ones.

14 INT. JUNIPER'S CAR - DAY

14

Juniper in middle seat glances at Laurel, staring out the window.

JANE

When we get home, you gonna go to
him or me?

SEYMOUR

I'll do it.

15 INT. JUNIPER'S HOME - DAY

15

Jane and Seymour head to their room, grab a belt.

Seymour opens to an empty, tidy room.

Downstairs, Jane screams.

16 EXT. JUNIPER'S HOME - DAY

16

Seymour exits.

ON THEIR PATIO:

IS JOHN, HANGING.

Juniper's eyes go wide. He runs inside.

So does Laurel.

Seymour and Jane grab the rope and try to cut it.

CUT TO BLACK.

JUNIPER (V.O.)

In the year and four months after
Bullock was elected, my brother John
killed himself.

17 EXT. JOHN'S FUNERAL - DAY

17

At a funeral home:

Dogs gather. Many claiming their condolences.

Juniper stares at his dead brother.

Only family nearby.

Two dogs- ARCHIE and BEAU- a beagle and a bernese mountain dog- stand by the side. They're dressed in suits, with special top hats labeled GOVERNMENT.

Seymour approaches them, tears in his eyes.

SEYMOUR

Yeah, he was always such a spoiled kid... Such a good one, too.

Archie crosses his arms, looks away.

ARCHIE

Can't believe the world's so corrupt
he'd kick the bucket over it.

SEYMOUR

I know. Those damn reformists,
pushing all their agendas against
us.

Beau squints at his brother's casket.

BEAU

Must be hard.

Juniper glares at Seymour. He goes to the bathroom.

He calls Louis.

18 INT. LOUIS'S HOME - DAY

18

Quiet house. Louis answers.

LOUIS

Hey. I heard.

19 EXT. JOHN'S FUNERAL - DAY

19

Juniper opens his mouth- but just hangs up.

20 INT. LOUIS'S HOME - DAY

20

Louis holds his breath- then sighs.

21 EXT. JOHN'S FUNERAL - DAY

21

SEYMOUR

I can't imagine what it's like for
all of you to be here. Having to
(MORE)

SEYMOUR (CONT'D)
 grieve the death of my kid.
 Halcyon's very own. Now I can
 imagine you all have questions. Why
 did my kid tie himself and throw
 himself over our patio?

Some laugh.

SEYMOUR
 Answer's simple. It's a harsh world
 we live in. There are too many
 people packed in one place. Too
 many. And when rich meets poor, when
 standard meets extreme...
 (takes off glasses)
 I'm afraid that can affect a kid's
 mental health to the point of
 exhaustion.

A kid in the crowd nods.

SEYMOUR
 My son, just like I, have endured
 these problems for years. And I
 think the stress of it all- school,
 work, life- got to him.
 (nods)
 And for years, reformists have been
 pushing against our family and what
 we stand for. So let this be a
 lesson to all the people out there,
 upset with our very existence, who
 want change and to push back against
 society's efficiency. That we
 deserve better! We deserve better!

More nods from the crowd.

SEYMOUR
 Let this be a declaration of war
 against the other side, against the
 others who would expose my child to
 propaganda until there is nothing
 left of him!

A few yes's.

SEYMOUR
 Good bless the mainland!

CROWD
 God bless!

Seymour steps off podium. Jane comes on next.

LAUREL

Now that's one less coworker to compete with.

The crowd laughs. Archie and Beau remain stone-faced, standing by the exit.

LAUREL

My brother, was lazy. He was bitter. He was an angry person. But above all that, he wa family.

PR-ass speech. Juniper gets up and heads to the back.

Archie and Beau block him.

ARCHIE

You're Seymour's kid.

Juniper nods.

Archie and Beau frown at Juniper. They nod at him and lead him back.

Juniper debates calling Louis. He taps Louis's phone icon.

It RINGS- but goes straight to voicemail.

22 INT. LOUIS'S HOME - DAY

22

Louis is under the sheets. His phone is on Do Not Disturb.

23 EXT. JOHN'S FUNERAL - DAY

23

Juniper sighs. He heads back in to people clapping for Laurel. A few slow claps.

An audience member whispers:

MEMBER

This is Seymour's new heir?

Chuckles from the audience.

Jane goes up.

JANE

I didn't get to see John much, since he spent so much time at work with his father, but I did just want to say, I love you John, and I'm sorry for everything.

Juniper pauses. He glances up at Jane.

JANE
I'm sorry. We're sorry. We failed
you. This world did.

The crowd sits, unamused. A tear appears in Jane's eye.
She fights it.

JANE
(shaky)
That's it. Thank you.

The crowd claps, albeit small claps.

Jane sits down. Juniper glances at the floor. He stands
up-

SEYMOUR
Now, let us proceed for-

Seymour notices Juniper.

SEYMOUR
Oh, you wanted to go?

Juniper stands. Everyone looks at him.

SEYMOUR
I mean, it's fine if you wanna go.
Everyone, he prepared a letter and
everything, it was so cute.

The crowd ahhs.

Seymour glares at Juniper.

Juniper takes another step.

SEYMOUR
Although, uh, you know, time's
running up, so... Make your
decision.

A man stares at his watch. Juniper looks around, at the
room of intimidating faces.

ALL DOGS AND DEER.

He sits back down.

SEYMOUR
Okay. Give it up for June anyways!
June!

The crowd claps for June. He stares at the ground, fuming.

SEYMOUR
Let's pray? Then we can get cake?

The crowd laughs.

HOURS LATER:

The crowd grabs cakes. Juniper takes off his suit and RUSHES out of the venue.

Jane notices him.

24 INT. JUNIPER'S HOME - DAY

24

Juniper appears at John's door. He opens it.

He pushes into John's room, grabs a letter, reads the first line.

He folds it and places it in his pocket.

25 EXT. JUNIPER'S HOME - DAY

25

Jane appears at the driveway- still in dress.

JANE

June? What happened, where are you going?

JUNIPER

Petunia's.

JANE

(points)

Petunia's is just across the street, dear.

JUNIPER

Well- well then I'm taking a detour around the country.

JANE

June. You can tell me anything you want me to know. I'm here for you.

Juniper stares at his mom. His tired mom.

He takes a step down.

JUNIPER

I'm... I'm going to Louis's.

JANE

What?

JUNIPER

I'm going to Louis's.

Jane pauses. Her eyes fall to the ground.

JANE

Okay.

JUNIPER

Don't tell Dad.

Juniper walks down the pavement, as Jane-

Tired-

Sits back down on the porch, and grabs an old cigarette pack.

She smokes on the porch like old times.

26 INT. LOUIS'S HOME - DAY

26

Louis bites his lip. Just as he does-

KNOCK KNOCK KNOCK.

He whips on his clothes and opens the door.

LOUIS

(flustered)

Hey.

JUNIPER

Hey.

Inside Louis's bedroom:

The two boys lay, staring at the ceiling.

JUNIPER

He said some shit about westside and how they pressured John into killing himself.

LOUIS

The fuck does that mean?

JUNIPER

Hell if I know.

Juniper stares at the ceiling.

LOUIS

You good if I rub your arm?

JUNIPER

Do whatever you want.

Louis rubs Juniper's arm consolingly.

JUNIPER

What if I just lived here again? My whole life. Across from you. And I could walk ten seconds instead of going all the way through town just to see you.

Juniper grabs Louis's arm.

LOUIS

(laughs)

What if we hate each other?

JUNIPER

Then we'd just have to suck it up.

LOUIS

We'd be like old roommates who dated for half a year.

JUNIPER

Then we'd go the other half avoiding eye contact.

Louis sits up.

LOUIS

June? How do you feel about your brother?

Juniper sits up.

They stare at eastside.

JUNIPER

My stomach hurts. I want food.

Louis cooks halibut for Juniper.

LOUIS

Second payback. Now we're even again.

Juniper smiles, scoffs. He eats the halibut.

Suddenly, the door opens. Louis grabs Juniper, thinking it's Hazel-

But Hazel locks herself in her room, quiet.

Belinda and Henry get in afterward.

Belinda squints. Then turns the corner.

BELINDA

Hey, Juniper! You good?

JUNIPER
Yeah! Louis makes great halibut.

BELINDA
(laughs)
Ah! That's good.

Belinda crosses into the kitchen, mixing spices.
Meanwhile, Henry- exhausted- puts on the news.

BELINDA
Let's see...

Juniper's smile fades.

Belinda taps Louis. Louis heads outside.

27 EXT. LOUIS'S HOME - DAY

27

Belinda points to the water bill. It's higher than usual.

BELINDA
We're gonna need you to get a job.
Soon.

LOUIS
Mom, I haven't heard back from the
universities.

BELINDA
That doesn't matter, get a summer
job.

Louis crosses his arms.

BELINDA
Have you decided what you wanna be
when you grow up?

Louis shakes his head.

BELINDA
Then go apply to Grillzy's. Work
half time or something. Just
something.

LOUIS
No, Mom... I-

Juniper inside the house.

LOUIS
Mom, I-

BELINDA
You'll have him. You'll be with him.

The wind blows. Louis glances at the ground.

BELINDA

Okay, fine. You really think you're gonna be friends forever? You really do?

Louis stares at the ground.

BELINDA

Louis, he's a dog.

LOUIS

Don't give me that bull-

BELINDA

He's a dog with money.

Louis crosses his hands.

BELINDA

(laughs)

And unless you fucking marry him? You're not getting the same dream job. No. Not in a million years. He's miles ahead of you in what he's got.

LOUIS

You won't get it.

BELINDA

What don't I get, what don't I understand? Baby, you can talk to me.

LOUIS

(sighs)

No I can't.

Louis gets up and opens the screen door.

LOUIS

Mom, Hazel's worrying me. I'm worried about her.

BELINDA

Then talk to her. Because I tried.

Louis SHUTS the door.

HENRY

Was just talking to June. Say, Lou, you wanna come and learn to drive with me?

LOUIS
With- what, with June?

Juniper gives a thumbs up.

HENRY
Your mom talk to you?

Louis nods.

HENRY
Then come on.

28 INT. LOUIS'S CAR - DAY

28

Henry shifts the car into gear and drives.

Juniper, backseat, smiles.

HENRY
Basics, basics first!

Louis switches out with Henry.

Louis turns a corner- but SHOVES the pedal.

Louis and Juniper laugh.

HENRY
Aye, aye, aye! Don't turn so fast!

LOUIS
(laughs)
I got this!

Louis stuffs it, but it lurches the car forward into the parking lot.

29 EXT. WESTSIDE ELEMENTARY - DAY

29

Louis stares at the sign of his old elementary school.

HENRY
So when you turn, it's SMOG. Signal,
mirror, over the shoulder, turn.

Juniper watches from the backseat. He glances at Louis in the mirror, smiles at him encouragingly.

HENRY
You okay, June?

Juniper nods. He opens the back window.

He folds his hands on his laps and glances outside.

As the car jolts and jerks, the clouds pass overhead.

And Juniper stares into the sky.

A single, small tear comes from his eye. As the car jerks and leaps.

Louis and his father laugh. Juniper laughs quietly as another tear comes out, silent.

HENRY

Your turn, June? Wanna try?

Juniper snaps to.

JUNIPER

Uh, yeah- fuck yeah! I'll try!

HENRY

That's the spirit!

The car parks on the side of the road. This time, Henry gets in the back.

HENRY

Now turn turn turn-

Juniper turns around the edge, slow and steady.

HENRY

There you go. Better than my own kid!

LOUIS

I wasn't that bad.

Henry and Juniper laugh.

30 EXT. JUNIPER'S HOME - DAY

30

Juniper halts in front of the driveaway.

He gets out, then goes inside.

And Louis- for the first time-

Sees the home.

It's perfectly mowed, edged, two story, with stairs leading up.

Henry chuckles, shakes his head.

HENRY

You better not get on his bad side, eh?

LOUIS

Oh, I know that.

Henry switches out. Louis heads back home.

31 INT. JUNIPER'S HOME - DAY

31

Juniper opens the door. He heads upstairs.

All the doors are closed.

MONDAY is tomorrow.

CUT TO BLACK.

CHOIR (V.O.)

Hail Mary, full of grace, the lord
is with you. Blessed art thou
amongst women, and blessed is the
fruit of thy wombed Jesus...

32 INT. CLASSROOM - DAY

32

Students, one by one, hand in their final papers to their
AP Tests.

Petunia and Rosaline leave the classroom.

They take a deep breath... Then exhale.

33 INT. TALENS HIGH - DAY

33

With grad night posters all over the hallway:

PETUNIA

That was your last one, right?

Rosaline nods.

Petunia sighs. They fall into each other and hug.

The hallways are peaceful today. Except for, maybe,
another fight.

The two rush out.

As kids filter out:

Louis, Juniper, Petunia, Rosaline, and Eve sit by the
bleachers, watching track and field.

EVE

So that's it? We just get school off
for a week, then we graduate.

The group nods.

EVE

Any ideas for grad night?

The wind blows.

LOUIS
Let's investigate a ghost town or something.

JUNIPER
Or go to Fjord and shop, I guess.

PETUNIA
What if we just stay home and eat ice cream all night?

ROSALINE
We could do all of those. I mean, we have a week off.
(beat)
You guys just don't have the money, though...

Eve and Louis huddle, lean forward.

JUNIPER
I'll cover.

PETUNIA
Yeah, me too, I'll literally do you guys solids and buy you all the ice cream you want.

ROSALINE
I want us to have fun.

Louis and Eve hunch further.

EVE
I... I got something with the band.

LOUIS
And Mom wants me to get a part time or something.

PETUNIA
But you guys don't have to do that now, right?

Louis and Eve don't respond.

LOUIS
I mean, we could do grad night-

ROSALINE
It just won't be the same without you.

A kid finishes a lap- their mile.

EVE

You know what? We do deserve to have a little fun. After all, I don't know how much we'll see each other after highschool, lest college.

Juniper nods.

JUNIPER

We're running out of time. I feel like we all say we're gonna hang out after high school, but...

Juniper glances at his hands. He shrugs.

Rosaline sighs. She gets up.

ROSALINE

Okay, well if you guys are done moping, I'm gonna take a walk downtown, you feel me?

The friends nod.

LOUIS

Fuck it, let's go.

34 EXT. DOWNTOWN - DAY

34

The group walks downtown, making jokes and laughing at one another.

35 EXT. OUTSKIRTS - DAY

35

The group sits by a pond, Petunia and Rosaline swimming in actual clear water. This time, Petunia's phone is in a plastic bag- sure not to get wet.

36 INT. TRAIN TRACKS - DAY

36

The group splits off.

37 INT. LOUIS'S HOME - NIGHT

37

Louis opens the door to Hazel's room. She stares at the door, at Louis.

LOUIS

Hey, big sis.

38 INT. CHAPEL - NIGHT

38

Juniper arrives at church. He sits down next to a priest.

JUNIPER

Bless me father, for I have sinned.
(MORE)

JUNIPER (CONT'D)

It's been a year and 4 months since my last confession. Since my last confession, my brother killed himself.

The priest nods.

JUNIPER

But instead of honoring that, I've been thinking about a man in my life, who I think I'm attracted to. He's not even my own species. He's a bear.

The priest nods, albeit slower, judgemental.

JUNIPER

I've been spending time with his family instead of my own.
(sighs)
It's hard for me to get along with my family, especially now, because...

39 INT. JUNIPER'S HOME - DAY

39

John fights Seymour.

40 INT. CHAPEL - NIGHT

40

JUNIPER

Of all the times my brother fought my dad... I think killing himself is just the latest issue.

Juniper pats this pocket.

JUNIPER

I stole. I stole this note from his bedroom. And in it, he curses out the Lord, and he curses out animal society as a whole, he says everyone's arguing, left and right, and he says he wishes he was never born.

JUNIPER

A part of me now wishes the same thing, to follow him and throw away all I was born with, um, because like him, I think I hate the world.

He glances at the ground, his jaw contorting. For the first time, he shows teeth.

JUNIPER

This hatred is a sin. It's wrath.
It's wrath, for myself, for my
family, for the entire world. And I
feel like if I don't ask for some
kind of guidance, this wrath'll stay
with me for the rest of my life.

He breathes, quiet.

JUNIPER

Amen.

PRIEST

Okay. The world is full of hatred.
But you must pray. Only when you
pray will you find your faith. And
once you stop seeing the hate in the
world, and you embrace the kindness
of the Lord, that's when your wrath
will cease to exist.

Juniper nods.

PRIEST

Embrace kindness. Trust the kindness
of the world. Yes?

Juniper nods.

JUNIPER

Yes, father.

PRIEST

Five hail mary's, five our fathers,
five glory be's.

Juniper buries his head in prayer.

41 INT. JUNIPER'S HOME - DAY

41

Juniper walks upstairs, to Jane.

JUNIPER

Mom?

Jane nods. Juniper's breathing grows deeper, his eyes
manic with fear.

JANE

Yes?

JUNIPER

Can I tell you something? But you
have to promise that you'll take
this with a grain of salt.

JANE

I promise. You can tell me anything,
as I said.

JUNIPER

What do you think of bisexual
people?

JANE

They're okay. Why?

JUNIPER

Like, what if someone in our family
was bisexual?

JANE

Well...

Jane pauses, still thinking.

JUNIPER

There's a guy I like.

Jane drops her toothbrush. Her breathing grows faster.
Juniper notices this- he backpedals.

JUNIPER

I-it's not Louis. I just, wanted to
tell you I'm bi.

Juniper sighs, a weight off his chest.

But Jane falls to the ground.

JANE

After all we did...

JUNIPER

Mom, listen, if you're not okay with
it, just tell me, and maybe I'll go
for girls.

JANE

After all we did to protect you...
To keep you away from ideas that...
from poison.

JUNIPER

Mom, I can go for the girls if you
want. I like girls, too. That's what
bisexuality is.

Jane begins to sob.

JANE
 After everything...
 (sobs)
 After everything, after we moved
 just so your dad could have an
 easier time raising you all.

JUNIPER
 Mom.

JANE
 After all we've done for you! We
 gave you lunch, packed, every day!
 And this is what you pay us back
 with?!

Juniper pants, hyperventilates.

JUNIPER
 Mom, I just- I just- I'll go for
 girls!

JANE
 Glory be to the father, and to the
 son, and to the holy spirit-

Juniper bursts into sobs. He falls onto the floor of his
 parents' bathroom, sobbing.

JANE
 Oh my god, I am heartily sorry for
 having offended thee. And I detest
 all my sins because I fear the loss
 of heaven, and the pains of hell-

JUNIPER
 Mom, please. Mom... Please. John is
 gone, I just want my Mom.

JANE
 (yelling)
 But most of all because I offended,
 thee, my god, who is so deserving of
 all my love!

JUNIPER
 No! No!

As Jane prays-

42 EXT. JUNIPER'S HOME - NIGHT

42

For the first time, the two story home looks like a
 prison.

A BODY falls to the ground-

43 EXT. LOUIS'S HOME - NIGHT

43

As Louis falls to the floor, and Hazel SLAMS the door on him.

Louis glances up at his room, as Belinda and Henry STORM inside.

He covers his eyes before the first punch lands.

CUT TO BLACK.